GADE7322 · NIGHTLIGHT · UI DIRECTION · V5 "INSIDE HIS HEAD"

Crayons vs Nightmares

You are inside a kid's head, fighting off his nightmare. So the HUD shouldn't look designed at all. It should look like **he** made it: crayon drawings, torn notebook paper, gold star stickers and sticky tape. The nightmare is the opposite: wet black ink, dripping red letters and scribbles that don't stay still. The two fight over the screen. When the kid's sanity is high, his drawings fill the HUD. As the Dream Core gets hurt, the ink crawls in from the edges, scribbles over his drawings and starts to break the text.

1. Two sides fighting over the screen

The kid (sanity)

- Crayon, coloured pencil, wobbly lines
- Torn paper scraps, lined notebook pages, tape
- Warm, bright colours: yellow, orange, sky blue, green
- Handwritten font, a bit messy, with spelling-test energy
- Gold star stickers are the tokens. Stick figures are the defender slots.
- Defenders are his drawings: a paper plane, a slingshot, a torch

The nightmare

- Wet black ink, splatters and frantic scribbles
- Dripping red lettering that jitters
- Almost no colour: black, blood red, a sickly green
- Glitched, broken letters once it is winning
- Enemies are scribbled black shapes with red eyes
- It never gets a panel of its own. It eats the kid's panels instead.

Sanity drives the whole HUD

Sanity is the Dream Core's health. The HUD reads it every time `OnCoreHealthChanged` fires and moves between three states:

SANITY	STATE	WHAT THE HUD DOES
100 to 60%	**Brave**	Clean crayon drawings, bright colours, the sun face in the sanity bar is smiling. Ink only lurks in the far corners.
60 to 30%	**Scared**	Ink creeps in from the edges and scribbles over the corners of paper scraps. The sun face looks worried. Warning text drips. Lines start to "boil" (wobble) a little faster.
Below 30%	**Losing it**	Ink covers the screen edges and tears the panels. Crayon colours drain to grey. Labels glitch and misspell themselves ("Sh00ter"). A slow heartbeat pulse. The nightmare's eyes open in the ink.

2. Layout rules kept from Bloons TD

RULE	THIS VERSION	READS FROM
Key numbers always visible	A crayon **sanity tug of war** across the top: the kid's sun on one side, the nightmare on the other, pushing a jagged line between them. Gold stars and stick figures top left.	`GetCurrentHealth` / `GetMaxHealth`, token pool, `GetDefenderCount` / `GetMaxDefenders`
Wave progress	Written by the nightmare under its side of the bar: "NIGHT 7 · 23 LEFT" in dripping red	`GetCurrentWaveNumber`, `OnEnemiesRemainingChanged`, `OnWavePhaseChanged`
Shop with prices, greyed when too expensive	Drawings taped along the bottom. Too expensive: scribbled over in grey pencil.	`ENightlightDefenderStyle`, the HUD's can afford check
One start control in the corner	A drawing of his bedside lamp: "LIGHTS OUT" with the countdown. Pull the chain to start early. In a wave it becomes a sticky note: "FASTER!!"	`GetBuildTimeRemaining`, `StartNextWaveNow`
Upgrade panel on selection	A page torn from his school notebook. Tiers are stars he colours in. (U key)	`FNightlightUpgradeTier`, `BPI_Upgradeable`

Bloons TD 6 (Ninja Kiwi) is only a reference for layout. No art, icons, fonts or names are taken from it. Costs and upgrade names are placeholders.

3. Colours and fonts

Notebook paper	Sun crayon	Orange crayon	Sky crayon	Grass crayon	Nightmare ink	Nightmare red
#F4ECD6	#FFC93C	#FF8A3D	#4AA3FF	#5CC96B	#0A0509	#D21F3C

My Shooter ★ 120

Gochi Hand: the kid's handwriting, for all of his UI.

IT'S COMING

Rubik Wet Paint: the nightmare's dripping letters, for wave labels and warnings.

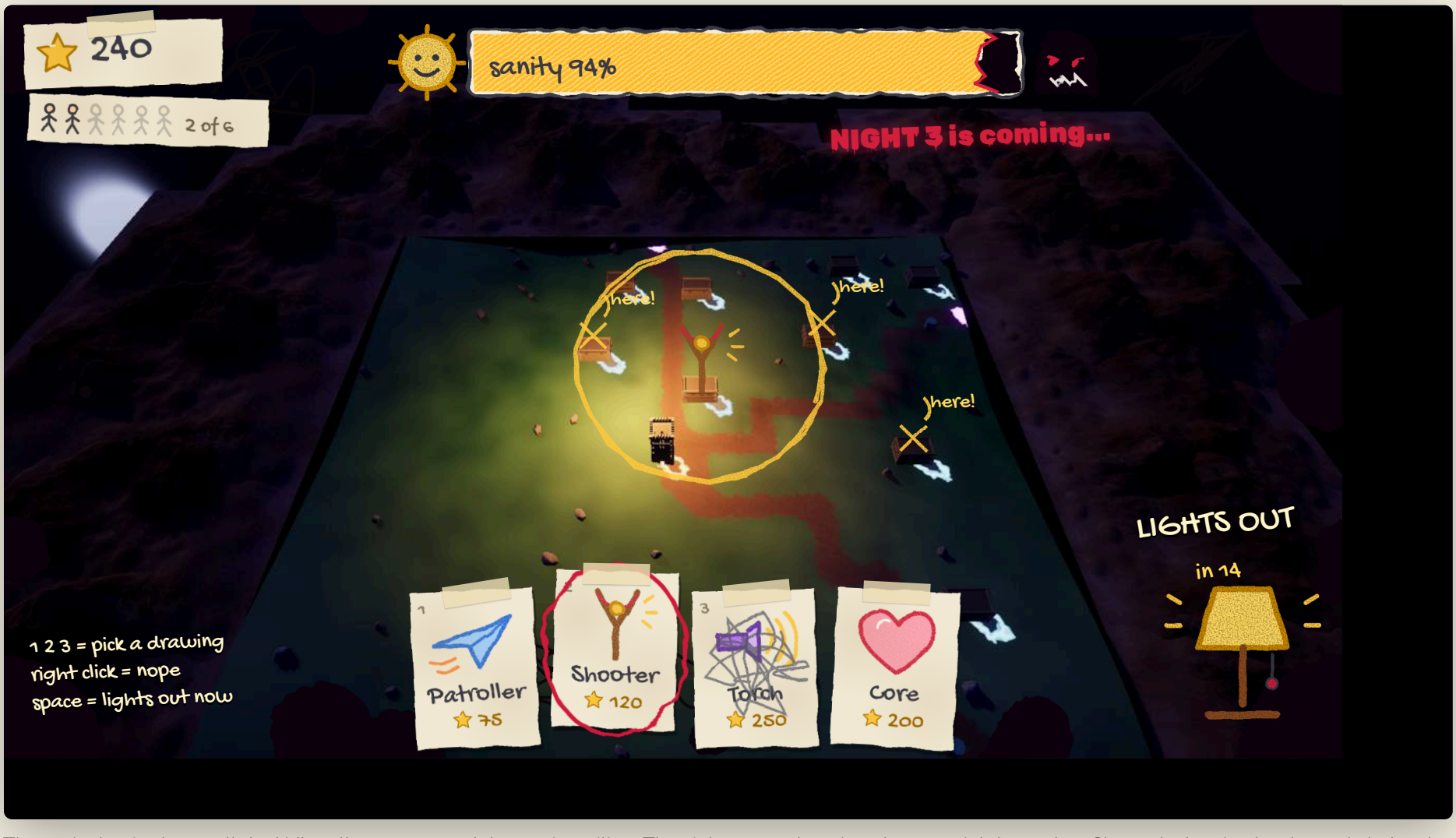
ShOOter

Rubik Glitch: swaps in when sanity is low and the nightmare is breaking the UI.

All three are free Google Fonts under the Open Font License.

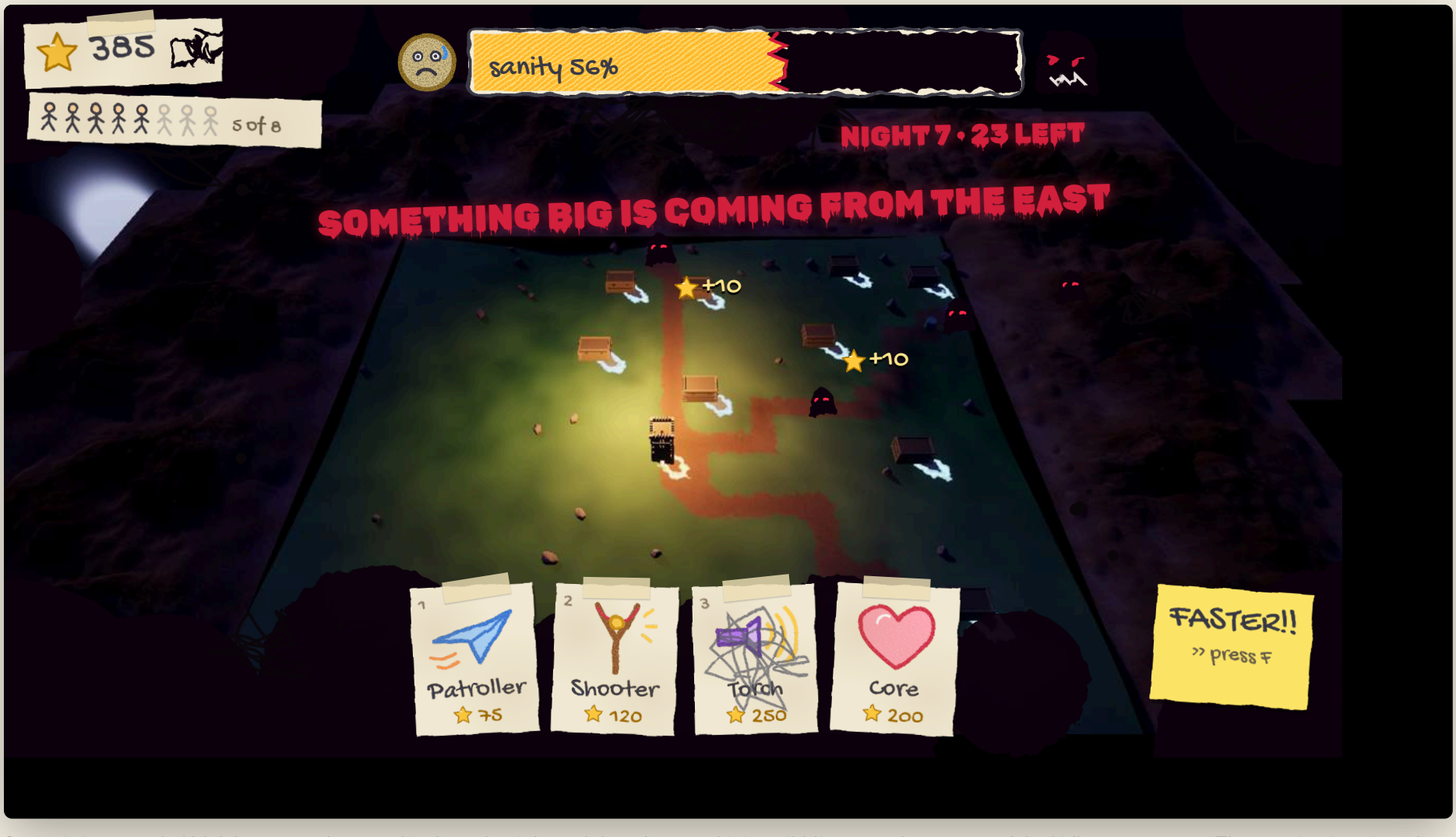
4. Mockups

A. Build phase, sanity high ("Brave")



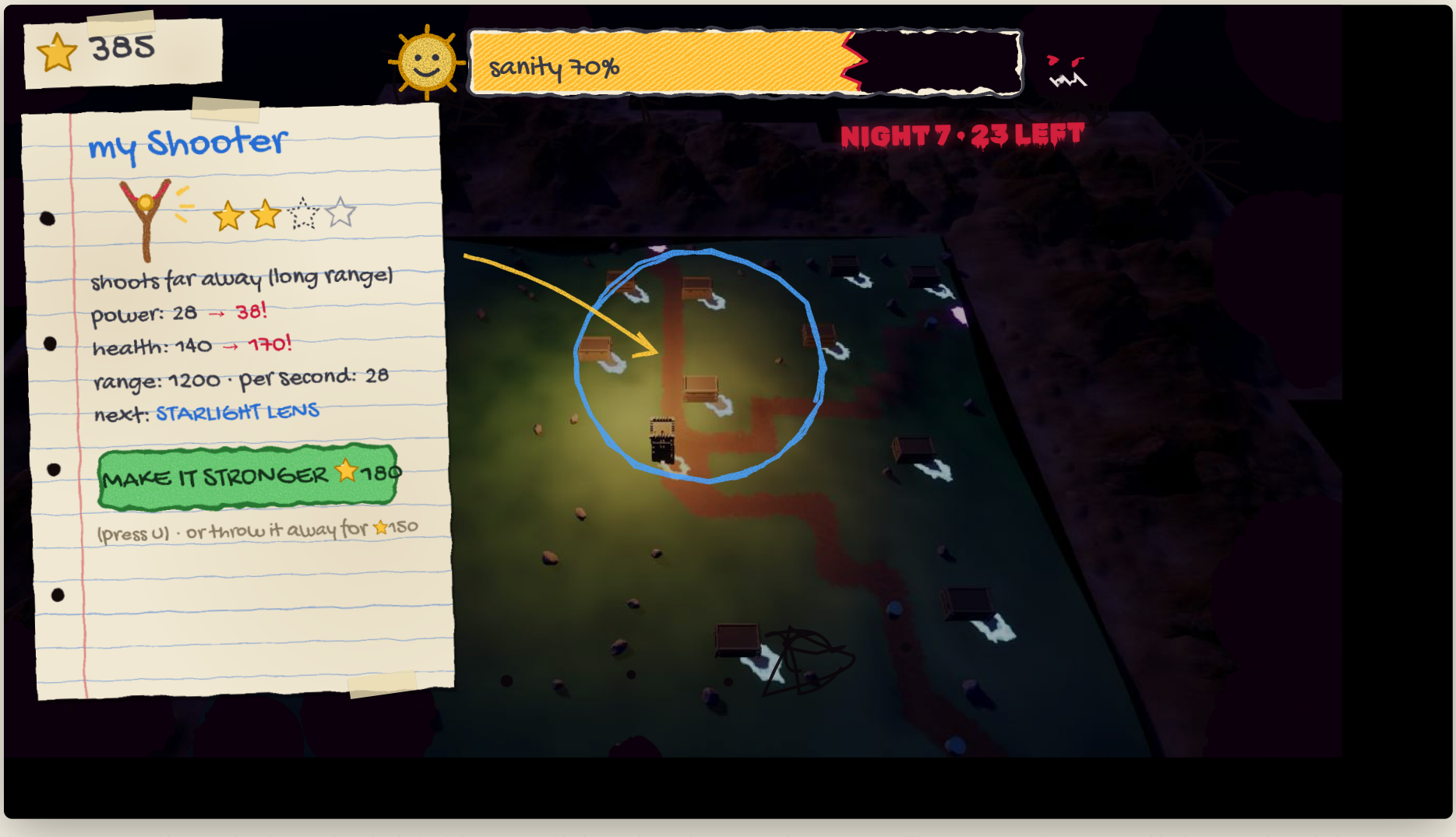
The sanity bar is almost all the kid's yellow crayon and the sun is smiling. The nightmare only writes the next night's number. Shooter's drawing has been circled and lifted, and the range is a wobbly crayon circle around the platform. The torch (Pulse) costs too much, so it is scribbled out in pencil. The lamp counts down to lights out.

B. Mid wave, the fight ("Scared")



Sanity is just over half. Ink has started to crawl in from the right and the edges, and it is scribbling over the corners of the kid's paper scraps. The warning is written by the nightmare in dripping red. Gold stars pop out of defeated nightmares. The lamp has turned into a sticky note for speed.

C. Upgrading a defender (U key)



A page torn out of his notebook, taped to the left of the screen. He has coloured in two of the four stars. The next upgrade is written like homework, with the stat changes as arrows. The Core uses the same page with a heart drawing instead, and its upgrades add more stick figures (defender slots).

D. Sanity low ("Losing it")

This is what the player should be afraid of. The ink has covered the edges and torn into the panels. The kid's colours have drained, the sun is scared, and the labels are glitching ("Sh00ter", "St4rs"). The nightmare's eyes have opened in the ink and it writes straight across the middle of the screen.

E. Wave cleared



The ink pulls back to the corners and the kid draws over the middle of the screen: "WE DID IT!!" with stars. The summary is on a scrap of paper, fed by `OnWaveCleared`, then the lamp counts down to the next lights out.

5. Building it in Unreal

Make the art by hand

- Draw the icons, panel scraps and lamp with real crayons on paper, then scan or photograph them. It is quick and it can't look like any other game.
- Tear real paper for the scraps and scan those too, with a transparent background.
- Ink splats and scribbles: draw with a marker or ink pen, scan, and make them pure black with alpha.

Line boil

- Draw (or slightly trace) each icon three times and cycle the frames at about 8 fps. The wobble makes it feel hand drawn and alive.
- Cheaper option: a UI material that offsets UVs with a slow noise texture.
- Boil faster as sanity drops, so the HUD itself looks nervous.

The ink overlay

- One full screen Image with a UI material: a scanned ink texture masked by a noise texture compared against a `Sanity` parameter. Lower sanity means more of the mask passes, so the ink grows inward from the edges.
- Add a panner to the noise so the ink edge crawls slowly.
- Below 30%, fade in two red eye sprites inside the ink and drop the saturation of the HUD widgets.

Widgets and order

- 1. `WBP_SanityBar` and the ink overlay (they carry the whole idea).
- 2. `WBP_StarCount` and `WBP_StickFigures`.
- 3. `WBP_LampButton` with `StartNextWaveNow`.
- 4. `WBP_DrawingShelf` with a `WBP_DrawingCard` per defender.
- 5. `WBP_NotebookPage` for upgrades (defenders and the Core).
- 6. `WBP_NightmareText`: dripping warnings, and the glitch font swap below 30%.